



University
of Glasgow

School of Law

LLM Dissertation Guidelines
(Masters)

Session 2025/2026

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1 General Issues

COURSE NAME	LLM Dissertation
LEVEL OF COURSE	Masters
CREDIT VALUE	60
IS THE COURSE COMPULSORY	Yes*

** All LLM students at the University of Glasgow are required to write a dissertation and will either participate in this course or the collaborative dissertation course. Please note that students on the Erasmus Mundus Masters in Law programme undertake a separate dissertation course and are directed to the Erasmus Mundus Moodle for more details.*

USUAL PERIOD OF STUDY

Students begin work on their dissertations after the course exam period (usually in spring) and are required to submit at dates to be advised each year (usually mid-August).

TEACHING METHOD, HOURS AND VENUE

The Dissertation course consists of independent research guided to a limited extent by a supervisor with some expertise in the student's chosen research topic. Supervision consists of up to two contact points, which in 2025-26, and in line with current University Guidance and policy, will be conducted in-person and/or virtually (e.g. Zoom, Teams).

STAFF AND HOUSEKEEPING MATTERS

Course Convenors:	Dr Mohamad Janaby Mohamad.Janaby@glasgow.ac.uk Dr Gavin Faulkner gavin.faulkner@glasgow.ac.uk (from Semester 2)
Course Admin:	Learning and Teaching Office, Room 225, Stair Building law-dissertation-pgt-enquiries@glasgow.ac.uk
External Examiner:	Depends on the topic of research.
Head of School:	Professor Claire McDiarmid Claire.McDiarmid@glasgow.ac.uk
PGT Director:	Dr Liv Naidoo Livashnee.Naidoo@glasgow.ac.uk

OBJECTIVES OF THE COURSE

The objectives of the course are:

1. To demonstrate a student's ability to complete a major and worthwhile piece of work, with some guidance, but largely self-motivated and with a minimum of supervision.
2. To demonstrate a student's ability to write an academic project which is well organised, and which clearly and concisely communicates its content to its readers.
3. To demonstrate the application of knowledge of law gained through coursework, and perhaps by practical experience, to a specific area of study, and to demonstrate a thorough knowledge and understanding of that specific area of study.
4. To demonstrate a student's ability to recognise and formulate a problem and to demonstrate the qualities of inquiry, logical reasoning, and analysis in addressing that problem.

RELATIONSHIP TO PROGRAMME AND COURSES

The dissertation is compulsory for all LLM Students.

In order to qualify for the award of a titular LLM (such as, for example, the LLM in Corporate and Financial Law) the dissertation must relate to a subject encompassed within the titular LLM (for example, 'Transaction Avoidance on Insolvency: An analysis of cases arising since the Financial Crisis'). Please ensure that you attend this rule when selecting a topic for research. See 3.1 (below) for more details.

Please observe that students on the Erasmus Mundus Masters in Law programme undertake a separate dissertation course and are directed to the Erasmus Mundus Moodle for more details.

METHOD OF FINAL ASSESSMENT

The dissertation is assessed based on the Masters marking scale; but, given the variety of different types of dissertations, the different emphases which may be adopted by students, and the wide range of topics, there can be no standard set of criteria which can be applied in assessing all dissertations. The weight attached to some criteria will also differ according to the nature and subject of the dissertation. Some features which are generally present in successful dissertations of all types, however, are as follows:

1. The student has achieved something worthwhile and has learned from the experience.
2. The student has demonstrated a critical and reasoned analysis of the subject.
3. The student has understood the relevant literature.
4. The area of study has been clearly defined, and a specific problem has been identified and addressed.

2 FAQs and Key Points

The dissertation is a substantial piece of work designed to test your ability to engage in independent research and critical analysis of a clearly defined subject area.

Before you start your dissertation

- For students who commenced the LLM in September 2025, the deadline for submitting dissertation preferences is **Friday 13 February 2026**. By this date, you must upload your first and second dissertation topic choices—each from a different sub-field—via the course Moodle page. For students enrolled in the General LLM, two proposed dissertation titles must be submitted, each drawn from a different pathway area. For example, if the first choice falls under the *International Law* pathway, the second should be selected from another pathway, such as *Commercial Law* or *Intellectual Property Law*. The purpose of submitting two topic choices is to provide greater flexibility in allocating a suitable supervisor.
- When submitting your preferences, please ensure that you specify both the **proposed title** and the corresponding **area of study** for each choice. For example:
 - o First choice title: “*A Critical Assessment of Section 172*”; Area of study: *Corporate Governance*.
 - o Second choice title: “*The Impact of International Arbitration on Cross-Border Commercial Disputes*”; Area of study: *International Commercial Law*.This information is essential for the allocation of supervisors and must therefore be completed as thoroughly as possible.
- Your dissertation topic may fall within any area of law, provided a suitably qualified supervisor is available. However, please note that, in order to be eligible for the award of a **titular LLM**, your dissertation must fall within the subject area covered by that specific programme.

During the writing process

- The dissertation is to be **12,000 words** in length. Footnotes count. The bibliography does not.
- The final hand-in date for the LLM Dissertation for the academic year 2025-26 is **Thursday 13 August 2026 at 4pm**.

Supervisory meetings

- **International students on a Student or Tier 4 Visa** who are remaining in the UK to write their dissertations must have two in-person or virtual meetings with their supervisors, the first in May, and the second in June. Such students are also required to attend the July pre-completion workshop. Each of these occasions will count as contact points for UKVI requirements (i.e. one with one contact point in each of May, June, and July). See generally guidance at: <https://www.gla.ac.uk/myglasgow/registry/tier4/responsibilities>.

All other students are required to have a minimum of one and maximum of two in-person or virtual meetings with their supervisors, the first of these to take place in May, in line with detailed guidance below.

- ***I have refined my title, and my supervisor agrees, do I need to do anything?***

Yes, email law-dissertation-pgt-enquiries@glasgow.ac.uk to advise of the new (agreed) title.

- ***Can I use parts of essays I have written?***

No, dissertations must not substantially incorporate another piece of assessed work – e.g. a class essay for which a grade has been given that forms part of your final mark. You must familiarise yourself with the University of Glasgow plagiarism policy (see also 3.5 below).

- ***How can I get an extension?***

Ensure you are keeping your supervisor informed of any difficulties you may be facing, particularly if this may impact your ability to submit on-time. **Extensions may not be granted by individual supervisors.**

If you and your supervisor are in agreement that an extension is necessary, you can apply for an extension of up to 5 working days via the School of Law Helpdesk.

Requests can be made from Thursday 6 August 2026. Any requests made prior to this date may not be considered until after this date. Requests made less than 48 hours before the submission deadline may not be processed in time.

If your extension request totals more than 5 working days (including any short-term extension applied for as above), you should submit an Extenuating Circumstances claim. Please note that you will need to supply supporting evidence. Please see point 3.8 below for further information on how to request an extension and on the Extenuating Circumstances process.

Please note that there may be further updates and changes to the above arrangements. You will be informed in due course if there are any changes to how this system will operate.

After submission

- ***Who will mark my dissertation?***

Your supervisor will first-mark your dissertation. Additionally, another academic will second-mark. In case of disagreements between these markers, the relevant LLM Pathway Director for your programme will review the work as a third marker. External examiners also review dissertation samples to ensure robust and fair assessment procedures.

- ***Will I receive any feedback?***

Marking comments will usually be visible on Moodle after the grades have been released. However, these comments are unlikely to be extensive and will not serve formally as feedback (or better feed-forward) for students, as you will finish your degree with the dissertation. That said, we do hope that you find the comments are informative.

3 Guidance to Students on the LLM Dissertation

3.1 CHOICE OF TOPIC AND CONTENT

3.1.1 General

Your chosen topic may be in any area of law, so long as a supervisor with expertise in the subject area is available. In order to be eligible for the award of a titular LLM, the title must lie in the subject area covered by that LLM. The topic need not be taught in a course within your LLM programme. Your topic may include non-legal elements, such as social history, philosophy, politics and economics; it might even be the case that the issue cannot be adequately addressed without reference to such material. But you should remember that the dissertation is part of a law degree and will be assessed as such.

It is generally good advice to choose a precise and focused topic on which it is possible to write a comprehensive paper. It is difficult to try to tackle a large topic, since there is a temptation to describe only arguments made by others. The topic should be one in respect of which you can sustain a substantial piece of original analysis. A topic which is too narrow may thus be inappropriate for an LLM-level dissertation.

Prior to the deadline for submission of the dissertation topic, Programme Conveners will hold a meeting with the students in their respective programmes, where there will be an opportunity to ask questions.

NOTE: IT IS UP TO EACH STUDENT TO UNDERTAKE THE NECESSARY RESEARCH IN ORDER TO EFFECTIVELY SELECT A TOPIC. STUDENTS SHOULD NOT REQUEST ACADEMIC MEMBERS OF STAFF SELECT TOPICS FOR THEM.

3.1.2 Submission of Two Titles

For students who commenced the LLM in September 2025, the deadline for submitting dissertation preferences is **Friday 13 February 2026**. By this date, you must upload your first and second dissertation topic choices—each from a different sub-field—via the course Moodle page. For students enrolled in the General LLM, two proposed dissertation titles must be submitted, each drawn from a different pathway area. For example, if the first choice falls under the *International Law* pathway, the second should be selected from another pathway, such as *Commercial Law* or *Intellectual Property Law*. The purpose of submitting two topic choices is to provide greater flexibility in allocating a suitable supervisor.

3.1.3 Level of Specificity

Your topic should be as specific as possible. It is not adequate to say your topic is “International Law”. An example of a sufficiently detailed topic might be: “My intention is to consider the impact the growing numbers and more extensive mandates of peacekeeping missions will have on the responsibility in International Law of the United Nations; I will focus on the draft ILC Articles on State Responsibility and rely on the Somalia mission as a case study.” Students should have done basic reading in the relevant area before formulating their proposed choice of topic. Where the selected topic is too broad, general or vague, it may be rejected, in which case the student will be required to submit a more specific topic.

For example, a focused topic in the field of International Law and Security could be: ‘The Legality of Targeted Killings Using Unmanned Drones Under International Law,’ or ‘Understanding international law as a perlocutionary act: how the diversity of the international society of States becomes the international community through the language of law.’ An example of an insufficiently focused topic would be: ‘Terrorism in the 21st Century – the threat, the legality and the application of international law.’ A topic where the focus is not clear is: ‘Diplomatic immunity is one of the attributed doctrines inside international law.’

Students are permitted to advance a topic which relates to law in a foreign jurisdiction. But the analysis must not be limited to the law of the foreign jurisdiction, unless that foreign jurisdiction forms a substantial part of a taught course. For example, the topic “The development of the new Chinese Competition Law” would not be permitted, but “A comparison of the new Chinese Competition Law with EU Competition Law” would be acceptable; however, the topic ‘The development of Chinese merger control’ might be permitted where Chinese merger control is addressed extensively in a taught course. In the case of any such comparison, there must be a balance between the two (or more) regimes being considered. Supervising staff are unlikely to have expertise in a single foreign jurisdiction. But they may be able to offer constructive supervision in relation to comparative legal approaches and relevant international standards.

3.1.4 Limitations on Materials and Academic Limitations

In selecting their topic and research focus within the selected topic, students must be realistic in their expectations of the University of Glasgow Library (UGL)

UGL invests heavily in both physical and digital content to support student assignments as well as dissertation research. However, since dissertation topics can be very diverse, it is possible that some material you require may not be in the collection. If UGL does not have online or library materials in a desired area, you should in the first instance contact the College Librarian, Lynn Irvine lynn.irvine@glasgow.ac.uk. She will discuss your information needs with you and try to source the material you require. Where it is not possible to get access to the information sources you need, you may have to decide if the problem is significant enough to require a change in focus. The College Librarian can order books and e-books to meet individual demand (though please note that there may be issues with securing print books during any Level 4 library and campus closures). There is a budget to support this. In this case, students would need to make a request by either contacting Lynn directly or using the Book Suggestion Form, which is available on the Library web page:

<https://www.gla.ac.uk/myglasgow/library/contact/forms/booksuggestionform/>

It would be advisable to discuss research resources with your supervisor **at your first meeting**, and to ask questions about how to approach the process of research and supervision, if you are unsure.

Students should consider whether the topic is one on which an available member of staff can supervise. If it is not within the expertise of any staff, the proposed topic will be rejected.

3.1.5 Substantial Overlap between Class Essays and Dissertation Topics

School of Law policy prevents students from writing dissertations in areas where there would be a substantial overlap with an assessed summative essay. Work can be submitted for assessment only once for a degree award.

Students will be able to submit the dissertation only on undertaking that the material submitted for assessment is the student's own original work.

Should questions arise regarding the existence of substantial overlap, students may be required to provide the Dissertation Convenor/s, their supervisor, or both, with a copy of their class essay, and may be called upon to explain the extent to which the material in the dissertation is different from that in the class essay. It is not sufficient to demonstrate merely that the dissertation contains *additional* material.

3.1.6 Rejection of Topic

If your topic is rejected on any of the above bases, you will be notified and asked to submit a new proposal.

As there are limited academic members of staff available in certain popular areas, it is possible that not all students will be permitted to write on the topic of their choice. Where there are a limited number of students who may write on a subject area, preference will be given to those applications that are received by the deadline. In the event that there is insufficient staff capacity to supervise in a particular subject area, it may be necessary for students to submit an alternate topic.

3.1.7 Ethical Research Policy

Ethical approval is needed for any research you plan to carry out using human data or material that is not already in the public domain. Most legal research will not require such approval as it will be based on materials such as statutes, case law, academic books and articles etc. If, however, you plan to conduct interviews, administer a questionnaire survey, or present case studies or any other material that is not publicly available, then you need to obtain approval for this **before proceeding**. Ethical approval is not required before submitting a Freedom of Information request.

If you are planning to undertake research using human data or material, your first step should be to speak to one of the Dissertation Conveners (if this is before a supervisor is assigned) or your supervisor, who should be able to advise you on whether or not ethical approval is needed. If you do need to apply for ethical approval, you can find further information about research ethics on the College of Social Science's Ethics website:
www.gla.ac.uk/colleges/socialsciences/students/ethics.

Application forms will be reviewed by the School of Law Ethics Forum. If you have any queries, then please contact the School Research Ethics Officer, Dr Amy Thomas (Amy.Thomas@glasgow.ac.uk).

In order to submit a completed dissertation, each student must a) attest to the fact that they have not engaged in research involving human subjects *or* b) provide documentation indicating the approval of the School of Law Ethics Forum for the research.

FAILURE TO OBTAIN PERMISSION FROM THE SCHOOL OF LAW ETHICS FORUM WHERE REQUIRED WILL RESULT IN NO GRADE BEING AWARDED.

3.1.8 Changes in Topic

Students will not normally be permitted to change their topics. Some refinement of the topic is, however, to be expected in the early stages in consultation with the supervisor at the first meeting.

ANY SIGNIFICANT REFINEMENT OF TOPIC MUST BE NOTIFIED TO THE COURSE ADMINISTRATORS.

3.2 SUPERVISION

One of the key objectives of the dissertation is to produce a substantial piece of work that demonstrates the ability to engage in independent research and critical analysis within a clearly defined subject area. The final submission must be the student's own work. Students are responsible for identifying the necessary tasks and carrying them out independently. The role of the supervisor is to provide guidance and advice.

Supervisors will not actively follow up on students' progress, and failure to submit work in accordance with the timeline outlined below may result in the supervisor being unable to provide feedback in time for necessary revisions. It is the student's responsibility to arrange meetings/contact points with their supervisor.

International students in the UK on a Student or Tier 4 Visa must pay particular attention to the schedule, especially the requirement for **supervisory meetings in May and June** and **in-person attendance at the workshop in July**, as these are essential for compliance with UKVI monitoring requirements.

3.2.1 Supervision Meetings

The supervision schedule, following approval of the topic and the assignment of a supervisor, is as follows:

1. **Initial meeting (May – all students):** The first meeting will focus on discussing the research and the proposed approach with the supervisor. Meetings will take place in line with current university policy, either in person at the University of Glasgow or virtually (Zoom, Teams etc.). **This meeting should (and for international students in the UK on a Student or Tier 4 Visa must) take place in May.** Please contact your supervisor as soon as possible to arrange a time and a suitable forum. Please refer to

the Glasgow Anywhere pages for support and advice regarding remote learning and teaching provision: <https://www.gla.ac.uk/myglasgow/anywhere/>.

At least three days ahead of this meeting, students must submit to their supervisor a research proposal, (please see 3.2.2 for the requirements of the research proposal). The research proposal will form the basis of the discussion at the meeting.

2. **Second contact point:** The purpose of this contact point is to review and obtain feedback on a draft of one section of the dissertation: no more than a single chapter or 3,000 words. The schedule for submission of this draft and the subsequent meeting should be agreed with your supervisor; however:

- a. **International students in the UK on a Student or Tier 4 Visa:** to comply with UKVI monitoring requirements, the second contact point must take the form of a supervisory meeting (in-person or virtual) and **must take place in June**. Students to whom this applies should accordingly be in touch ahead of time with their supervisors to agree on a schedule for submission of the work to be reviewed, in good time to ensure that this meeting takes place in June. Your supervisor will assess the draft for style and academic content and provide feedback during a virtual or in-person meeting at the University of Glasgow School of Law.

- b. **All other students:** as per international students in the UK, save that (i) while still strongly encouraged, it is not mandatory that this contact point take place in June and (ii) feedback may be provided by email in place of a meeting.

These two stages represent both minimum and maximum supervision. You may not contact your supervisor on more than these two occasions, and you may not send regular emails requesting advice, references to sources, or both unless you think there are very specific, exceptional reasons personal to your situation for doing so e.g. concerning protracted difficulties with reading and research resources, extension requests, etc.

It is *not* the role of the supervisor to suggest sources for your work, and you should have a clear view of what materials you will use, and how you will obtain them (subject to the library advice above). Please ensure that you use your contact points with the supervisor to ask questions, if you are unsure.

Many supervisors may be less available over the summer and when dissertations are being written. For this reason, for **those other than** international students in the UK on a Student or Tier 4 Visa, the second stage of supervision may be conducted by email as an alternative to a remote or in-person meeting.

Please note that it is students' responsibility to organise supervision meetings. It is important to plan your writing and arrangements with the supervisor in good time to ensure suitable supervisor availability, bearing in mind the periods of leave that supervisors will have planned, as the summer period approaches.

3. **Third contact point:** In addition to the supervisory contact points specified above, the School of Law will convene an **in-person dissertation completion workshop in July**. This workshop

is not a substitute for the May and June supervision meetings but serves as an additional academic support session. Attendance at this workshop is mandatory for all international students in the UK on a Student or Tier 4 Visa, to enable compliance with UKVI monitoring requirements. Attendance is optional (albeit strongly recommended) for all other students.

3.2.2 Research Proposal (to be sent to supervisor before the first meeting)

By the end of May, you need to prepare a research proposal and send it to your supervisor ahead of the first supervision meeting. The dissertation proposal should include the following sections:¹

- Overview – A general introduction that succinctly sets out exactly what the project seeks to explore. This should also include the research question(s) to be addressed and the overall aim of the project.
- Context – In this section, you should situate your proposed research project within the relevant literature(s). To do this, you may want to include a brief summary of research already taken in the field, addressing key works and scholars. Specific attention should be paid to problems in the existing literature and ways in which your proposed research challenges or addresses these problems. You should also give an account of the theoretical issues relevant to your research, and whether you intend to test existing theories or develop new ones.
- Methodology – In this section, you should provide a detailed account of how you will develop your research project by indicating your approach to your research (e.g. doctrinal, socio-legal, comparative), your sources of data, and the methods that you will use to collect and analyse that data. Moreover, you should pay particular attention to providing a justification for your choice of research approach, data sources and research methods that is appropriate for your research question.
- Ethics- An indication of ethical issues associated with your proposal (including those that may impact on formal ethics committee approval and those requiring ongoing consideration in the field/during analysis) and proposed actions to mitigate these.
- Preliminary outline - Provide a short chapter plan, showing how you intend to organise your argument. Each chapter should have a clear purpose contributing to the overall research question.

Your research proposal should not exceed 1,700 words. As a rough indication, your preliminary outline should not exceed 200 words, dedicating the remaining 1,500 words to cover all the other sections.

At the start of term 2 there will be a session dedicated to supporting you with the preparation of your research proposal. The exact details of this session will be announced closer to the time of the session.

3.3 SUPPORT FOR WRITING A SUCCESSFUL LAW DISSERTATION

You will find a comprehensive range of educational materials designed to assist you in developing your dissertation. These resources cover dissertation planning and structure,

¹ These sections have been adapted from the Research Proposal Application Form under the Scottish Graduate School of Social Sciences (SGSSS) Student-led Open Competition 2025/26.

research methods, critical reading and writing, methodology, literature review, OSCOLA referencing, and the use of software tools to support legal referencing. In addition, training workshops may be offered to further support your preparation and writing process. Please check the Moodle page regularly for updates.

3.4 DISSERTATION CONVENOR(S)

The Dissertation Convenor is Dr Mohamad Janaby (Mohamad.Janaby@glasgow.ac.uk). The role of the Dissertation Convenor is to administer the dissertation process with the assistance of the LLM Admin Team (law-dissertation-pgt-enquiries@glasgow.ac.uk). Chiefly, this role will include:

- allocation of your supervisor following submission of your research proposal.
- approval of any topic choices.
- general administration of the procedure with the aim of ensuring a smooth process.

In the event that a student has a concern about supervision and/or the dissertation process that cannot be resolved directly with the supervisor, please contact the Dissertation Convenors at the above email addresses. They will deal with the query and refer it to the PGT Director or the Head of School if necessary.

3.5 FORM OF THE DISSERTATION

3.5.1 Length

The dissertation should be no more than **12,000 words in length**. Footnotes and appendices (but not bibliography, title page, table of cases, table of abbreviations, dedications page or contents page) count in assessing the number of words. Dissertations will be judged by the quality of content rather than by length. Do not exceed the word limit.

Dissertations which exceed the word limit will be subject to marking penalties on the following scale:

Amount of excess	Deduction applicable
0-10% over limit	2 grades in the secondary band (e.g. from C1 to C3)
10-20% over limit	3 grades in the secondary band (e.g. C1 to D1)
20-30% over limit	4 grades in the secondary band (e.g. C1 to D2)
Each additional 10%	1 additional grade in the secondary band

NB: There will be no exceptions to this word limit.

NOTE: IN CASES WHERE THERE IS ANY DISPUTE ABOUT THE NUMBER OF WORDS, THE “WORD COUNT” OPTION IN MICROSOFT WORD WILL BE DETERMINATIVE.

3.5.2 Footnotes

All footnotes are included in the word count.

3.5.3 Bibliography

The bibliography is not included, although this should be purely an accurate and full reference to material relied upon or cited in the main body of the dissertation.

3.5.4 Presentation

Formal guidance as to the presentation of the dissertation is given at the end of this document. Please read carefully.

3.6 PLAGIARISM AND COLLUSION

3.6.1 Plagiarism

The University takes the view that its degrees and other academic awards are given in recognition of a student's personal achievement. All work submitted by students for assessment is accepted on the understanding that it is the student's own effort. Students may not, therefore, benefit from plagiarism. "Plagiarism" is defined as the submission or presentation of work, in any form, which is not one's own, without acknowledgement of the sources. All cases of alleged plagiarism, at whatever stage of a student's studies, whether before or after graduation, will be investigated and dealt with appropriately by the University.

The incorporation of material without formal and proper acknowledgement (even with no deliberate intent to cheat) can constitute plagiarism. Work may be considered to be plagiarised if it consists of (for example):

- A direct quotation that is not identified as such.
- A close paraphrase where the source is not indicated.
- An unacknowledged summary of a source.
- Direct copying or transcription.
- Material produced by artificial intelligence (AI) tools.

With regard to essays, reports and dissertations, the overriding rule is that if information or ideas are obtained from any source, then that source must be acknowledged. Any direct quotation must be placed in quotation marks and the source cited in a footnote. Any failure to acknowledge adequately or to cite properly other sources in submitted work is plagiarism.

For further guidance, see the University resources at:
<https://www.gla.ac.uk/myglasgow/sld/plagiarism/>

Re. AI specifically, see also guidance at: <https://www.gla.ac.uk/myglasgow/sld/ai/students/>

UGL guides on referencing are available at:
<https://www.gla.ac.uk/myglasgow/library/referencing/>

Where a student is suspected of plagiarism the case is referred to the Head of School or their nominee (unless s/he is otherwise involved with the assessment in question, in which case it will be dealt with by another senior member of staff) along with all appropriate documentary

evidence (e.g. the piece of work in question, a copy of the original source of the plagiarism, information on the contribution of the piece of work to the overall assessment, etc). Once this has been done there will be no further marking of the work, and the student shall be informed in writing that his or her marks have been withheld pending an investigation of suspected plagiarism.

The Head of School (or nominee/substitute) will then assess the extent of the suspected plagiarism and, if necessary, consult with the Senior Senate Assessor for Discipline. The Head of School (or nominee/substitute) will deal with suspected cases that are first offences and not considered to be severe. The Head of School (or nominee/substitute) will refer all suspected second offences and cases of severe plagiarism directly to the Clerk of Senate or to the Head of the Senate Office for investigation under the provisions of the Code of Discipline.

Examples of cases which would be regarded as severe plagiarism include:

- Any case involving a final year undergraduate or postgraduate student (taught or research).
- A first offence where a reduction in marks would put at risk the student's degree.
- Any case, regardless of extent, where it is inappropriate to deal with it within a School.

If the case is dealt with by the Head of School (or nominee/substitute) an academic penalty can be imposed (e.g. a reduction in grade); if the case is referred to Senate Office, the range of penalties is more extensive. **Any case of suspected plagiarism in respect of an LLM dissertation is likely to fall within the category of 'severe' plagiarism and is therefore likely to be referred to the Clerk of Senate or to the Head of the Senate Office.**

A full statement of the University policy may be found in the University Regulations: <https://www.gla.ac.uk/myglasgow/apg/policies/uniregs/regulations2025-26/feesandgeneral/studentsupportandconductmatters/reg32/>

Note that a plagiarism investigation can severely delay the completion of the programme and is likely to impact the date of your graduation.

3.6.2 Turnitin Plagiarism Avoidance and Detection Software

The University of Glasgow uses Turnitin software in a supportive and educative way. Turnitin is intended to support students in their avoidance of plagiarism and to support staff in their detection and prevention of it.

You will be asked to submit your work to the Turnitin system via Moodle where it will be compared to billions of current and archived web pages, many formally published journal articles, papers and books and to work submitted by other students. Following this initial submission, you will be able to look at the Originality Report produced by Turnitin showing where similarities to other work have been detected. Turnitin does not state whether plagiarism has or has not occurred; it merely highlights where your work is very similar to material already stored in its databases.

Following your initial submission, you can amend your own work if you need to and resubmit it to the Turnitin system.

3.6.3 Collusion

Collusion is cheating and arises where two or more people work together to produce a piece of work, all or part of which is then submitted as each individual's own effort. The dissertation is an individual assessment, and students should not collaborate in writing dissertations. Evidence of collusion will be referred to the Head of School, as per the process outlined in 3.5. (a).

3.7 TIMETABLE

STUDENTS ARE REMINDED THAT THEY MUST SATISFY THE RELEVANT PROGRESSION REQUIREMENTS BEFORE THEY ARE PERMITTED TO PROCEED TO THE DISSERTATION STAGE OF THE LLM DEGREE.

3.7.1 Submission

The dissertation should be **submitted electronically (through Moodle and Turnitin) by the due date.**

Submission of the dissertation is the sole responsibility of the student and it is the student's responsibility to notify law-dissertation-pgt-enquiries@glasgow.ac.uk if they fail to submit for whatever reason. A dissertation that is not submitted will be awarded H.

3.7.2 Timetable

Semester 1

- Think about possible dissertation areas and topics.
- Stage 1A: Attend the information lecture and view online LLM Dissertation materials released on the course Moodle.

Semester 2

- **Stage 1B:** Review the Dissertation Guidelines and attend the LLM Dissertation meeting with your Programme Convenor (schedule will be made available on the Dissertation course Moodle). Decide on a topic which interests you.
- **Stage 2:** Notify your topic choice via the submission form on the Dissertation Moodle page. The deadline for this is **Friday 13 February 2026**, for students who commenced the LLM in September 2025. All dissertation allocations will be managed by the Dissertation Conveners. Please note the supervision restrictions outlined in this guidance.
- Stage 3A: Prepare a dissertation proposal, including:
 - Working Title
 - Definition of Problem
 - Chosen Methodology

- possible chapters.
- Stage 3B: Refine your dissertation proposal and justify/support your methodology approach.
- Stage 4: First meeting with your supervisor

The first supervisory meeting should take place in May after exams (and for international students in the UK on a Student or Tier 4 Visa must take place in May) and may be conducted either in person or virtually.

Students should arrange the first supervision meeting with their supervisors (in person or remotely). It is up to students to make contact and arrange a suitable date and time.

Students should submit to their supervisors by email, in advance of the meeting, a research proposal. These plans should indicate clearly the area on which the dissertation will focus, the structure of the argument/dissertation, and the sources consulted or to be consulted in the future as described in 3.2.2. This research proposal in effect should make clear what the nature of the work is and how it will progress to conclusion.

At that meeting, students should:

- expect research proposal to be criticised and discussed.
- expect to be given advice or a limited number of references to enable them to more clearly define the dissertation aims.

Before end of June

- *Stage 5: Second contact point with supervisors (can be held online or in person).

Ahead of this contact point, students should prepare the initial stages of the dissertation. If they have a document in a suitable form, students may give their supervisor a draft of no more than one chapter, or 3000 words, by email.

*Please note that both supervisory meetings (i.e. in May and June) will count as contact points for international students in the UK on a Student or Tier 4 Visa. As such, the second contact point must also take the form of a meeting (in-person or remote) and **must** take place before the end of June.

July - August

- Stage 6: Complete research and write and revise the remaining chapters. This should proceed in a logical and planned way.

We recommend, for example, typing work, or having work typed, as data is collected. We similarly recommend ensuring that chapters are checked and proofread as they are prepared/completed. It is not practicable to leave this all to the end.

Students should be prepared to alter ‘finished’ chapters if the need arises, especially the introductory and concluding chapters.

- Stage 7: Completion of the research writing-up of all the chapters (and appendices).
- Stage 8: Collation of the dissertation and preparation of the ‘formalities’ (title page, acknowledgements, contents, etc.).
- During July, students should attend the in-person dissertation completion workshop at the University. (This will count as a contact point for UKVI monitoring purposes and so is **mandatory** for international students in the UK on a Student or Tier 4 Visa.)

August

- Stage 9: Submission.

RESPONSIBILITY RESTS WITH THE STUDENT AND NOT THE SUPERVISOR FOR ENSURING THAT THIS TIMETABLE IS COMPLIED WITH.

Please note: You are advised to plan for earlier completion of each stage wherever practicable. Any completion problems should be discussed with your supervisor and, if necessary, with the Dissertation Convenors, including changes to your circumstances that may require an extension request. Late submission of the final work will attract penalties unless an extension has been granted, or Extenuating Circumstances can be shown. The range of penalties is set out below.

Submission of the dissertation is the sole responsibility of the student and it is the student’s responsibility to notify law-dissertation-pgt-enquiries@glasgow.ac.uk, if they fail to submit for whatever reason. A dissertation that is not submitted will be awarded H.

3.7.3 Student Declaration

The Dissertation Declaration Form, duly completed by each student, must be submitted with the finished dissertation.

NOTE: IN LINE WITH UNIVERSITY POLICY, SUBMISSION SHOULD BE OF AN ELECTRONIC VERSION OF THE DISSERTATION VIA MOODLE AND TURNITIN TO ALLOW THE USE OF PLAGIARISM DETECTION SOFTWARE AND VERIFICATION OF WORD COUNTS.

3.8 NOTIFICATION TO STUDENTS

Notification to students is done by posting information via the dissertation course page on Moodle. It is the responsibility of all students to check this page regularly.

3.9 EXTENSIONS TO THE SUBMISSION DEADLINE

The method of requesting an extension depends on the length of the extension requested.

Extensions of up to five days. Where the requested extension is for a period of up to five working days, students must request an extension via the School of Law Helpdesk.

Any application for such an extension must be made before the submission deadline. **Extensions may not be granted by individual supervisors.**

An extension will only be granted where the candidate requesting the extension has been prevented by circumstances beyond their control from submitting the relevant work on time. Please note that in line with University policy, extensions will not be given for computer or other IT problems, or poor time management. An extension will be permitted only to the extent it would be commensurate with the duration of the circumstances causing the late submission (to a maximum of five days).

Where the application for an extension is not submitted until after the deadline for submission of the work, the extension should normally only be granted where the circumstances preventing the candidate from completing the work on time have also prevented him or her from applying for the extension in advance of the due date of the work.

NB It is very important, if you intend to request an extension, that you do so in good time. You are advised to make your request no later than one full working day prior to the submission deadline (i.e. submission deadline Friday at 4pm – submit extension request no later than Thursday at 4pm; submission deadline Monday at 10am – submit extension request no later than Friday at 10am).

Requests made outside normal working hours (Monday-Friday, 9am-5pm) will not be attended to until the next working day at the earliest.

Do not leave your request until the day before the deadline and so increase the likelihood of a late submission penalty being applied.

Extensions of over five days. Where the requested extension is for a period of over five days (or you are seeking a further extension beyond the initial five working day period) you should submit an Extenuating Circumstances claim, including supporting evidence.

A decision will be taken by the PGT Extenuating Circumstances Committee. An extension will only be granted where the PGT Extenuating Circumstances Committee is satisfied that the candidate requesting the extension can point to reasons which amount to ‘Extenuating Circumstances’ under the University regulations.

In short, ‘Extenuating Circumstances’ generally refers to illness or other adverse personal circumstances affecting a candidate and resulting in the candidate’s failure to submit coursework at or by the due time. The evidence required shall usually include a report descriptive of the medical condition or other adverse personal circumstances which are advanced by the student for consideration as amounting to Extenuating Circumstances.

An Extenuating Circumstances claim may be made in respect of late submission of a dissertation or non-submission of a dissertation.

Please note, however, that it is not possible to claim Extenuating Circumstances in relation to significantly impaired performance in the independent work required for a postgraduate taught master's degree (i.e. the LLM dissertation). This reflects the fact that Extenuating Circumstances is understood as relating to *acute* circumstances whereas the independent work takes place over a period of months. Over such a period, acute circumstances can be addressed through short extensions or, in exceptional cases, a longer deferred deadline. Please see [Code of Assessment](#), para. 16.45(a)(ii).)

You should consult the following sources of information if you are considering making an Extenuating Circumstances Claim:

- Regulation 16 of the Fees and General Information section of the *University Regulations* covers incomplete assessment and Extenuating Circumstances (paragraphs 16.45 – 16.53).

https://www.gla.ac.uk/myglasgow/apg/policies/uniregs/regulations2025-26/feesandgeneral/assessmentandacademicappeals/reg16/#incompleteassessmentresultin_gfromextenuatingcircumstances

<https://www.gla.ac.uk/myglasgow/apg/policies/assessment/#codeofassessment>

- Student FAQs on Extenuating Circumstances:

<https://www.gla.ac.uk/myglasgow/apg/policies/assessment/goodcausefaqs/>

- Absence report or Extenuating Circumstances Claim?

https://www.gla.ac.uk/media/media_424718_en.pdf

- Consider the guidance above in this handbook.

Note: *the above summary of the 'Extenuating Circumstances' regulations is for assistance only. You should consult the Code of Assessment of the Taught Postgraduate Programmes section of the 2025-26 University Calendar for a detailed and up to date discussion of 'Extenuating Circumstances'.*

The PGT Extenuating Circumstances Committee normally meets weekly, and Extenuating Circumstances claims will not be considered outwith this schedule unless considered urgent by the PGT Assessment Officer.

Please note also the time period for making an Extenuating Circumstances claim: in particular, claims must be submitted no later than five working days from when submission of the affected assessment is due. Notification later than one week after the dissertation due date shall not be taken into account unless circumstances have prevented the candidate from requesting the extension within this time. In considering claims of Extenuating Circumstances for the purposes of a request for an extension of over five days:

- the evidence provided by the student claiming Extenuating Circumstances, and any relevant and available material submitted by him or her for assessment shall be scrutinised.
- fairness to the individual student claiming Extenuating Circumstances must be balanced with fairness to other students and the integrity of the assessment as a whole.
- in the event of the student having failed to submit the dissertation by the due date, it shall be determined whether the failure to submit has been justified by Extenuating Circumstances.

Where a student requests an extension for Extenuating Circumstances, it shall be the responsibility of the student concerned to make the circumstances known to the Postgraduate Assessment Officer (who, in turn, will present the case to the PGT Extenuating Circumstances Committee) and to provide appropriate evidence.

It is your responsibility to bring to the attention of the University any factor that may have affected your academic performance in the dissertation and to seek appropriate support as needed timeously from your supervisor, LLM Dissertation Convenors, PGT Assessment Office and/or other member of staff. Students should also familiarise themselves with what does not constitute Extenuating Circumstances such as claims relating to the pressure of work on the LLM itself (for example, in respect of examination burdens); where it relates to computer malfunction; or where it arises in the case of a part-time student suffering from pressures at that student's place of work, save in the most exceptional circumstances.

Please note that you can only graduate after your dissertation has been approved at an Exam Board which is only held at set times during the academic year. The dissertation is also subject to various quality assurance processes. Any extension granted beyond the original deadline of Thursday 13 August 2026 may accordingly affect your ability to graduate with your cohort in Winter 2026.

Where an extension is granted, academic and MPA staff will endeavour to expedite any quality assurance processes to allow the dissertation to be approved at the relevant Exam Board to prevent delays to graduation. However, this is not within their control, and students should bear in mind the possibility of a delayed graduation when requesting an extension.

Please note that there may be further updates and changes to the above arrangements. You will be informed in due course if there are any changes to how this system will operate.

LATE SUBMISSION

Penalties for Late Submission

Where no extension has been granted penalties for late submission of work will apply. The penalties are as follows:

Days late	Deduction applicable
1 working day	2 secondary bands
2 working days	4 secondary bands
3 working days	6 secondary bands

4 working days	8 secondary bands
5 working days	10 secondary bands
6 working days	Award of “H” grade

3.10 DISSERTATION DIETS: LATE PROGRESS AND RESITS

The summer dissertation diet for the LLM and for all programmes runs from the end of the Spring exam diet (at the end of May) to August. This is the dissertation diet into which the majority of students will be entered, *unless* circumstances are such that the student falls into one of the categories below.

Per. provision 7.1 of the [generic regulations for taught Master's degrees](#), a candidate will be permitted to progress to preparation of the dissertation (the substantial independent work required by the degree), only if they have obtained a grade point average of 12.0 or above in the taught courses with at least 75% of the credits at grade D3 or above and all credits at grade F3 or above.

Students who do not achieve this GPA at the Spring exam diet will be advised to pause their progress on the dissertation and may be granted an opportunity to resit taught course examinations at the August exam diet. If successful at achieving the required GPA from this diet, students will then be permitted to progress to the dissertation and recommence their substantial independent work (this is called 'late progress'). The exam diet for late-progress students on the dissertation course runs from early September to November.

In accordance with of provision 9 of the [generic regulations for taught Masters degrees](#) a candidate will be eligible for the award of the degree on obtaining a grade point average of 12.0 or above in the taught courses, with at least 75% of these credits at grade D3 or above, and all credits at grade F3 or above, and obtaining a grade D3 or above in the substantial independent work. Where students do not achieve a grade D3 in the dissertation, they will be offered an opportunity to resit the dissertation after the determination of outcomes at the subsequent exam board (usually held in August). The resit dissertation diet runs from late November to February.

TOPIC SELECTION AND SUPERVISION FOR LATE PROGRESS AND RESITS

Students who progress late to the dissertation are expected to **continue with their original topic** selection (as submitted in February). Students who are entered into this diet are entitled to arrange two new contact points with their supervisor, although the first meeting may be 'light touch' and an opportunity to recommence the planned research. Students are advised that while the law school will seek to preserve previously made supervisory appointments wherever possible, this cannot be guaranteed due to possible changes in the availability of academics.

International students in the UK on a Student or Tier 4 Visa to whom this applies should be in touch with the LLM Dissertation team to ensure continued compliance with any relevant UKVI monitoring requirements.

Students granted an opportunity to resit the dissertation will be required to submit a **new topic** for independent study, which is clearly distinct from the first dissertation attempt. Students will be contacted by the LLM Dissertation team and asked to submit a new topic. A new supervisor will be appointed, based on suitable expertise, and the standard supervisory process outlined above ought to be followed (i.e., supervision contact points, the submission of a dissertation plan and a chapter draft for feedback).

PROSPECTIVE SUBMISSION DATES FOR LATE PROGRESS AND RESIT STUDENTS

- Late progress dissertation: Thursday 26 November 2026 (though note subject to change)
- Resit Dissertation: Thursday 18 February 2027 (though note subject to change)

EXAM BOARDS

Dissertations and degree awards can only be confirmed by the **Board of Examiners**. There are **two main** Board of Examiners meetings for the Masters degree at the School of Law. These usually take place in:

- **Spring/June:** primarily for considering course results and progression to the dissertation. However, where required, it will also consider the awards for any students who had a late progression dissertation result from the previous session.
- **October/November:** when the majority of awards are confirmed.

In addition, there are usually two further meetings of the Board of Examiners during the academic year: one (typically) in January, principally to confirm the results of Semester 1 courses, and another (typically) in August to confirm resit results (and late progression to LLM dissertation).

The assessment of students who submit the dissertation after progressing late to this course and those who submit the dissertation after being granted an opportunity to resit will likely fall to be considered at the Spring/June 2026 exam board. It is not possible for the final dissertation results to be available in time for the January 2026 Board of Examiners.

Please further note that the majority of students will be entered into the Summer Dissertation diet and that there is **no option** for students to choose a later diet. Only students that fit the circumstance of 'late progress' or the degree requirement to 'resit' the dissertation will be permitted to submit on the later dates noted in the preceding section.

4 Presentation of the Dissertation

4.1 Formalities

- Typing: double spaced
- Long quotations should be indented and single spaced.
- Checking and proof reading are your responsibility.
- Numbering: pages to be numbered consecutively
- The electronic copy is to be submitted via Turnitin on Moodle
- Submission: dissertation to be submitted electronically on the LLM Moodle page
- Length of dissertation: 12,000 words in length

4.2 Content and Layout of Dissertation

The layout of the dissertation should be as follows:

1. Title page
2. Acknowledgements (optional)
3. Abstract
4. Table of Contents
5. Main Text
6. Appendices (optional)
7. Bibliography

Items 2 and 6 are optional. All other items **must** be included.

Details:

1. **Title page** - Title, student no., purpose and date:

Suggested Layout – Example

TITLE

LEGAL POSITIVISM AND
INTERNATIONAL LAW

STUDENT
NUMBER

2001234

PURPOSE

SUBMITTED IN PART FULFILMENT
OF THE DEGREE OF LLM IN THE
UNIVERSITY OF GLASGOW

DATE

20XX

2. **Acknowledgements** (optional)

If you wish to acknowledge any assistance/support/ideas/co-operation, etc., it should be briefly indicated on a single page at this point.

3. Abstract

The main arguments and conclusions of the dissertation condensed into no more than 2 A4 pages (and preferably into a single A4 page).

Abstracts do not count towards your final word count.

4. Table of Contents

As a minimum this should include a list of chapter numbers, chapter titles and page numbers relating to the start of each chapter. This may, at your option, be expanded to provide information concerning sections of chapters, etc. However, the detail provided must not obscure the clarity of the Table of Contents.

Any appendices (see 6. below) should also be referenced in the Table of Contents.

An optional extra is a list of figures or tables, but this should normally only be provided if the tables and/or figures are considered numerous **and** worthy of being specifically referenced.

5. Main Text

The main body of the dissertation, divided into chapters and sub-headings as appropriate.

6. Appendices (optional)

Any appendix material is to be included in determining the overall length of the dissertation.

The appendices can either be grouped together at the end of the main text or included at the end of each relevant chapter within the main text. The use of appendices and the positioning of appendices are both optional, but if appendices are used the positioning should be consistent i.e. all appendices at the end of the main text or all following the relevant chapters.

7. Bibliography

This should include all works specifically referenced within the text and should contain the following details:

- Author(s)
- Title of publication
- Publisher
- Date of publication

The order should be alphabetical by author (or first named author with the second and subsequent authors providing the next sort fields) and by date of publication within author, for example:

(31) Hart, H.L.A., *Essays in Jurisprudence and Philosophy* (OUP 1983).

- (32) Hart, H.L.A., *The Concept of Law* (2nd edn, OUP 1994).
- (33) Hart, H.L.A. and Honore, A.M., *Causation in the Law* (2nd edn, OUP 1985).

The bibliography does not count towards your final word count.

4.3 Citations

A uniform system must be applied throughout the dissertation. Citations should be made in footnotes or at the end of the text. We recommend that you follow the style used by the Oxford Standard for the Citation of Legal Authorities (OSCOLA):

https://www.law.ox.ac.uk/sites/default/files/migrated/oscola_4th_edn_hart_2012.pdf.

If you need further guidance on this issue, you are advised to speak to your supervisor about the citation system that you choose to apply.